really want to start a war? The country was in bad shape, reeling under the Covid pandemic. The economy was faltering, global supply chains had broken down. Would we be able to ensure a steady supply of spares, etc., under these conditions, in case of a long-drawn-out action? Who were our supporters in the global arena, and what about the collusive threat from China and Pakistan? A hundred different thoughts flashed through my mind. This was no war game being played in a sand model room of the Army War College, but a life and death situation.

After a few moments of quiet reflection, I called Jo. 'We cannot be the first ones to fire,' I told him, as it would provide the Chinese with an excuse, a *casus belli*, to escalate and paint us as the aggressors. Even at Mukhpari (on the Kailash Range) the previous day, it had been the PLA who had fired first (being only two rounds by the PLA and three rounds by us, it had escaped the attention of the media). I felt that we should maintain this stance. Instead, I told him to move a troop of our tanks right to the forward slopes of the Pass and depress their guns so that the PLA would be staring down the barrels of our guns. This was done forthwith and the PLA tanks, which had by then reached within a few hundred metres of the top, stopped in their tracks. Their light tanks would have been no match for our medium tanks. It was a game of bluff and the PLA blinked first.

In the midst of all this, we had not forgotten about the area of DBO and Galwan, from where everything had started. This area, Sub Sector North (SSN), was also beefed up by sending an additional Brigade along with Mech Forces. Once again, while the Infantry was able to move quickly, the mechanized column had some issues of trafficability. The area of Eastern Ladakh which has a frontage of 800-plus km was the Area of Responsibility of 3 Mtn Division. This area had now been reinforced by another two Divisions with their complements of armour and artillery.

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